NOTES

BRIEFING FOR CITY COUNCIL · **GROUP 3**

260 menu items per container

Serving size **one dot**

Would you like sugar with that?

The council is weighing a fast-food ban. A ban treats all 260 menu items the same. We read the nutrition facts of every one to see where the problem actually sits. **Spoiler: 150 of them are not the problem.**

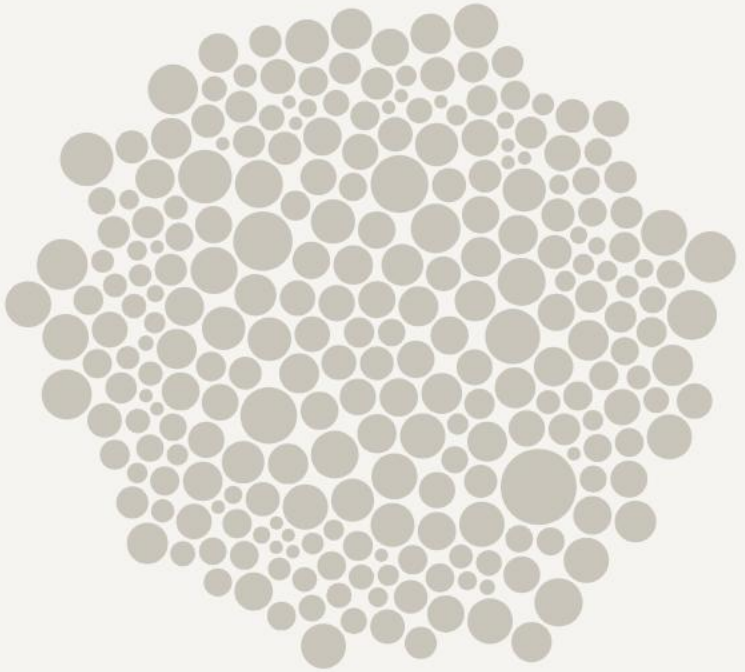
Menu items analysed **260**

A blanket ban removes 260 items. The data flags 110.

HOW TO READ

Each dot is one menu item. Bigger dot, more calories.

IE IMBA Data Fluency · Final group assignment. Use the arrow keys or a clicker to move through the story.



260 items. Where does the problem sit?

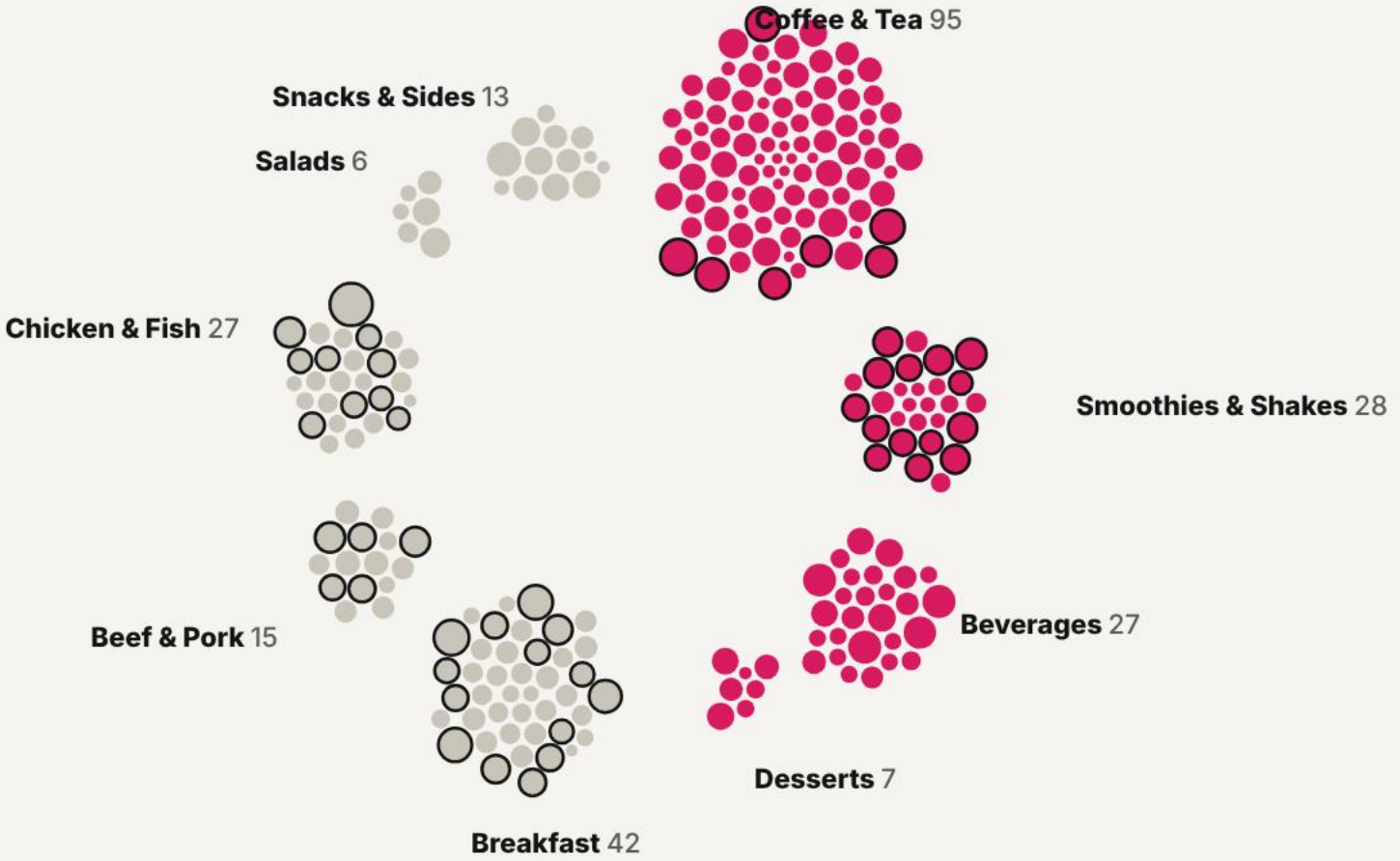
Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

NOTES

Six in ten menu items are drinks or desserts

157 of the 260 items are coffees, sodas, shakes or desserts. 21 of them carry more calories than a Big Mac.

Drinks & desserts **60%**



KEY

- Drinks & desserts
- Food
- More calories than a Big Mac (530)

all 260 dots are in our dashboard →

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

NOTES

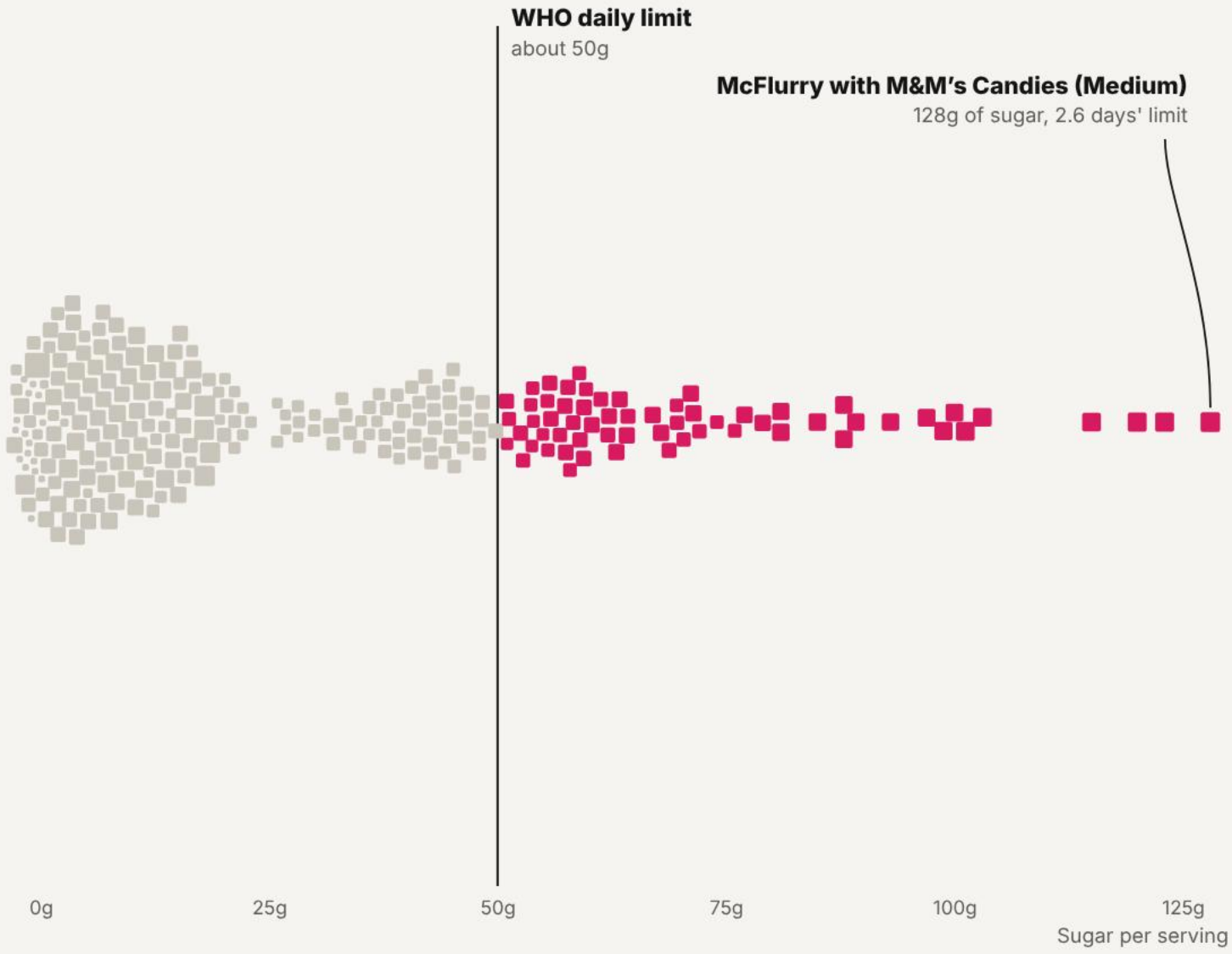
Every item over the daily sugar limit comes in a cup

62 items pass the WHO limit of about 50g in a single serving: shakes, McFlurries, sodas and sweet coffees. The sweetest food item has 32g.

Items over 50g of sugar **62**

KEY

- Over 50g of sugar
- Under 50g
- Bigger square, more calories



Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

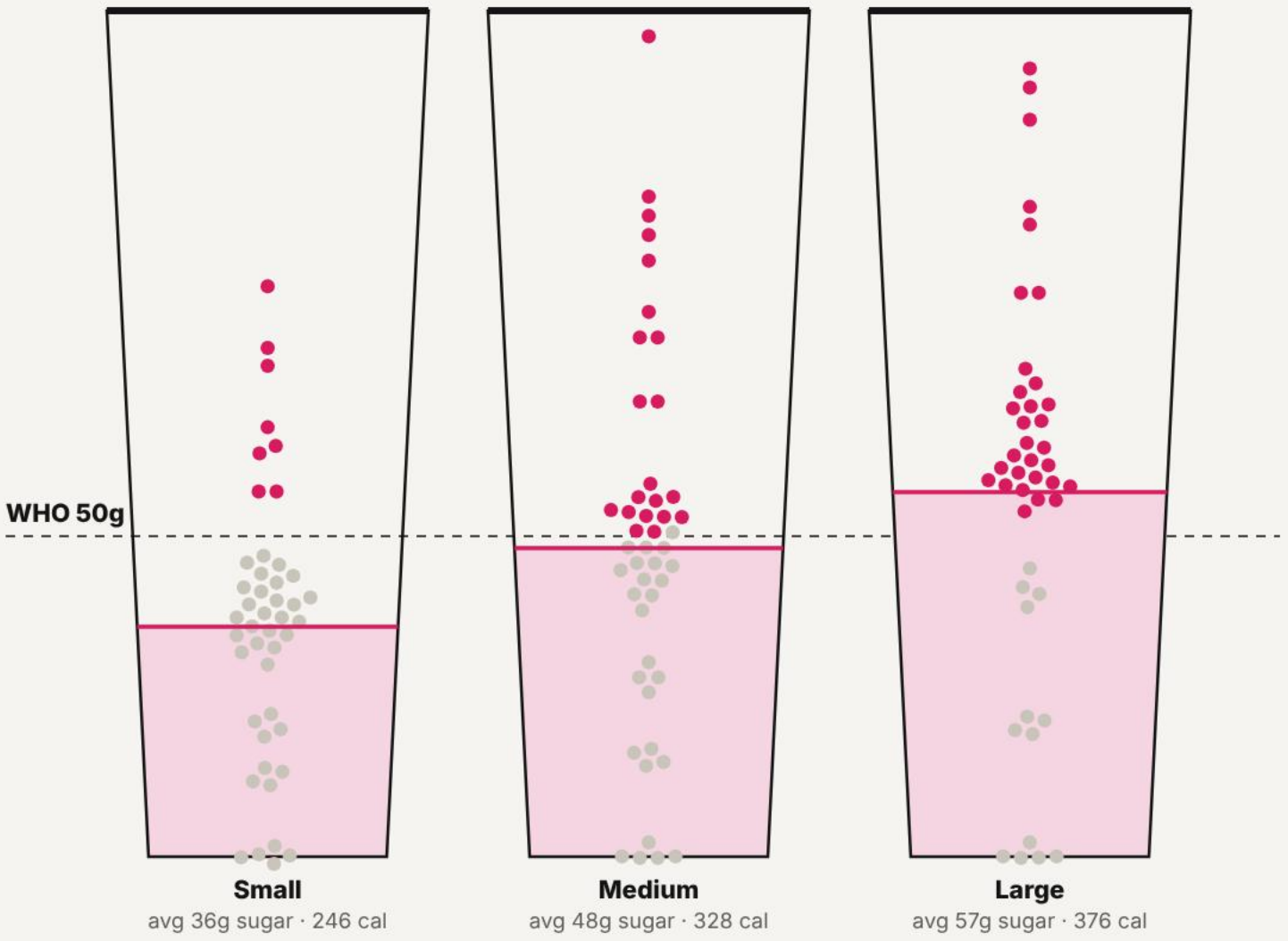
Each size up adds about 10g of sugar

Across 136 drinks sold in three sizes, the average Small has 36g of sugar, the Medium 48g and the Large 57g. The average Large is over the daily limit on its own.

Large vs Small **+21g**

KEY

- Over 50g of sugar
- Under 50g
- Fill line: average sugar per size. **Read the line, not the pink area.**



Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

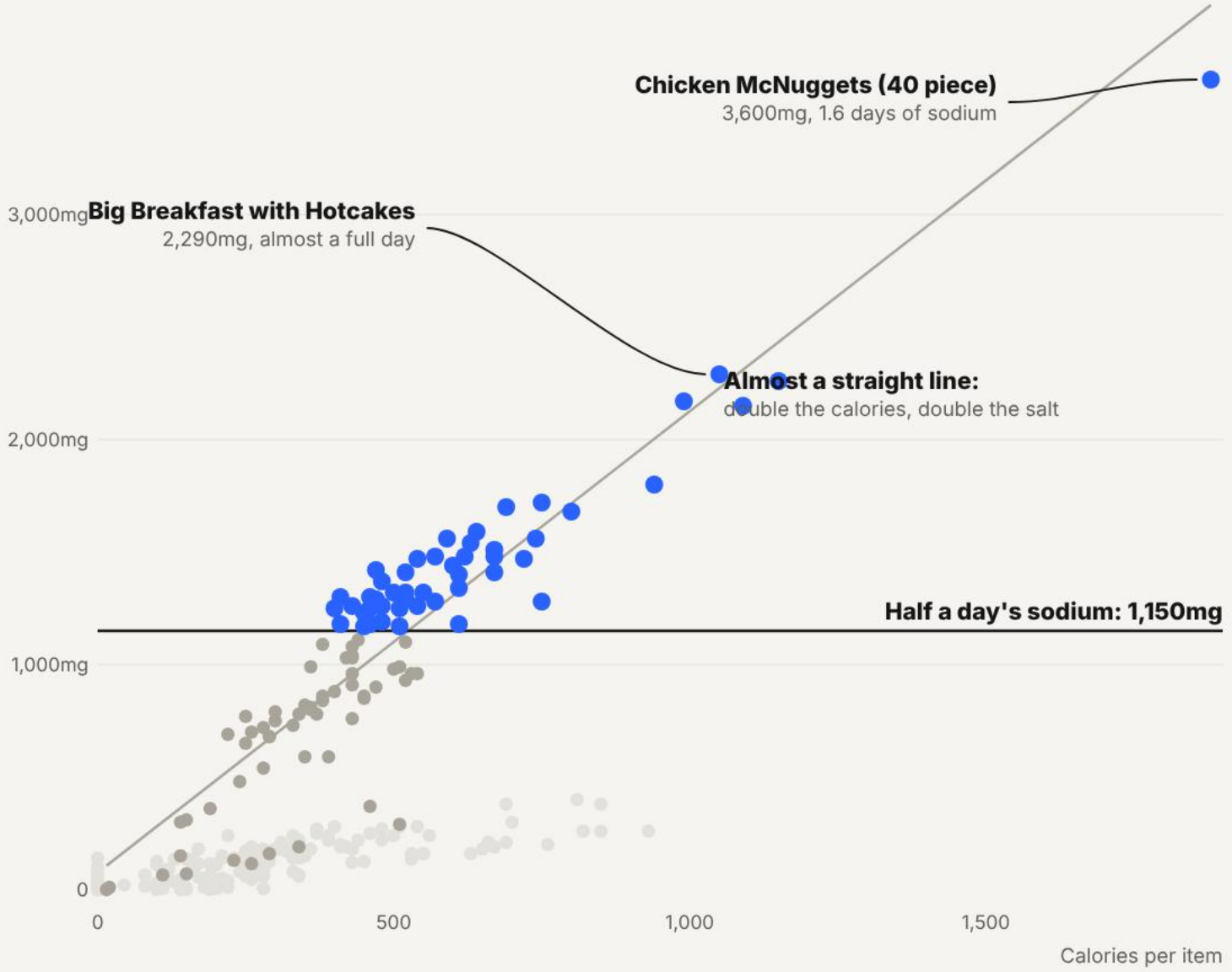
On the plate, the problem is salt

Food items barely carry sugar, but 48 of them hold half a day's sodium or more. The more calories on the plate, the saltier it gets.

Items with 1,150mg+ sodium **48**

KEY

- Food with 1,150mg+ sodium
- Other food
- Drinks & desserts



Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

SERVING 5 OF 6 · **SWAPS**

Same order, smaller or grilled

All 13 chicken dishes sold both ways lose 80 to 160 calories when grilled. A Small instead of a Large saves a median 130 calories and 21g of sugar.

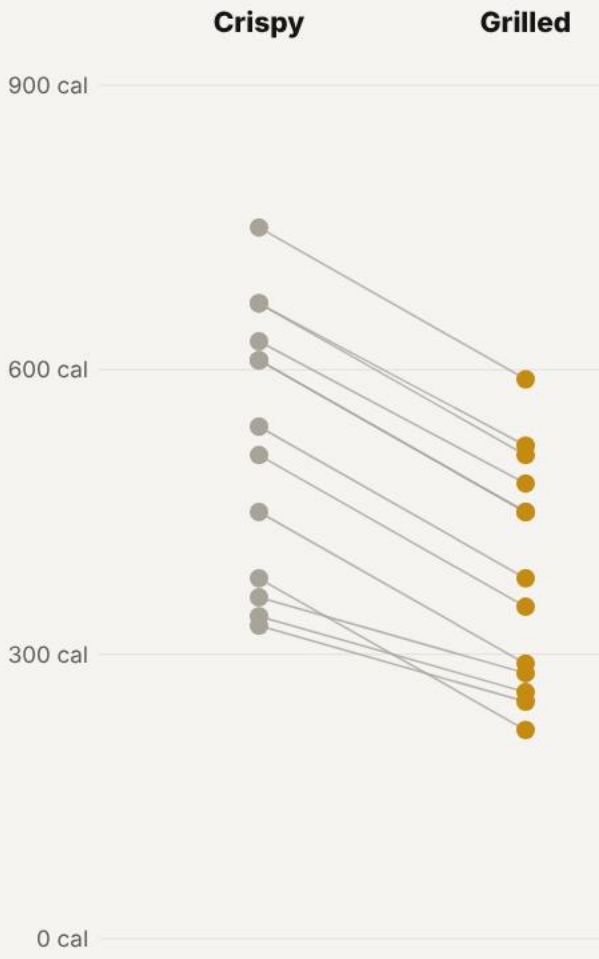
Calories saved per grilled dish

80–160

KEY

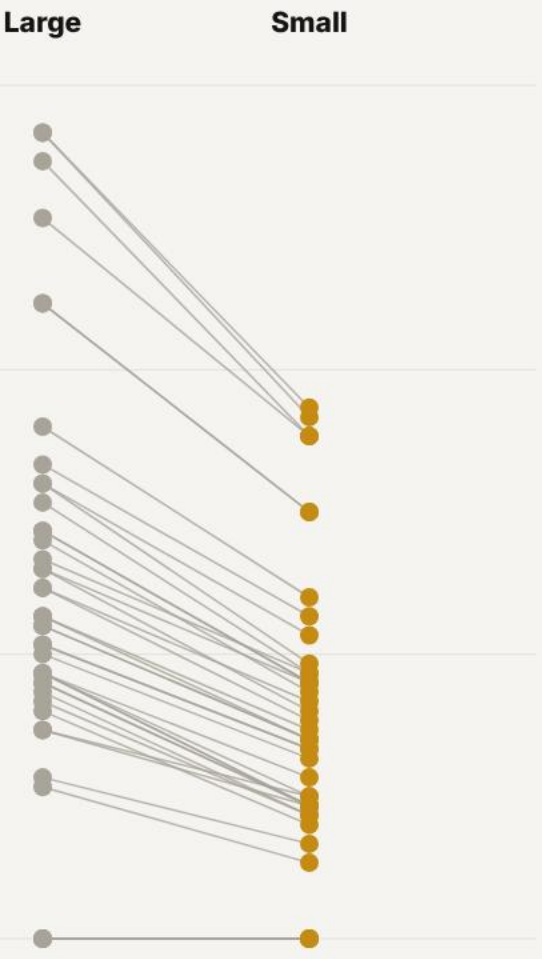
- What people order now
- The smarter version

13 chicken dishes sold both ways



Every dish drops: 80 to 160 cal

43 drinks sold in Small and Large



Median: 130 cal and 21g sugar

Flat lines: diet sodas, coffee, iced tea

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

SERVING 6 OF 6 · POLICY

Regulate the cup, not the counter

A ban removes all 260 items. Two warning labels would flag the 110 items that drive the problem and leave the other 150 alone.

Items flagged **110**

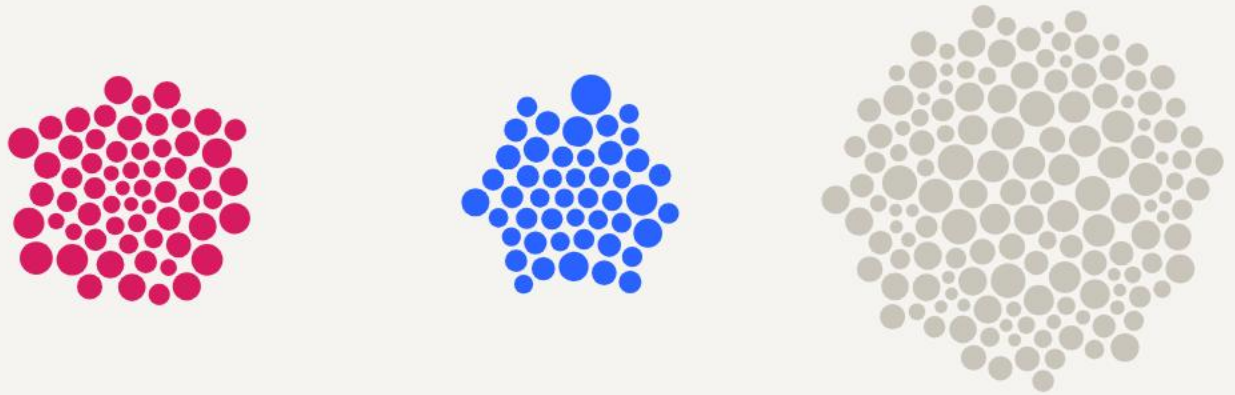
KEY

- Sugar over 50g
- Sodium 1,150mg or more
- No flag

Sugar over 50g
62 items, all in a cup

Sodium 1,150mg+
48 items, all food

No flag
150 items



MEASURE	REACHES	WHAT THE DATA SAYS
Small as the default drink size	136 drinks	Median 130 fewer calories and 21g less sugar per drink
Sugar warning at 50g+	62 items	Every one of them comes in a cup
Sodium warning at 1,150mg+	48 items	New York City's 2,300mg icon would flag only 1 item here
Grilled listed first on menu boards	13 dishes	80 to 160 fewer calories per dish

Precedents: New York City requires chain restaurants to show a salt-shaker icon next to items with 2,300mg of sodium or more. California makes water or plain milk the default drink in kids' meals (SB 1192).

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

AFTER THE MEAL · **RECOMMENDATION**

Pilot targeted rules before any ban

> Decision we ask for today: approve a six-month Small-by-default pilot with two or three chains.

Start where the data points: the drink cup and the salt on the plate. Measure what people actually order, then decide.

KEY

- Sugar flag
- Sodium flag
- No flag

NEXT STEPS

Pilot Small-by-default with two or three chains for six months.

Ask chains for sales data. A menu shows what is offered, not what is eaten.

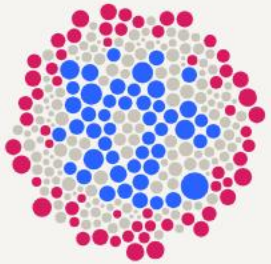
Repeat with local menus. Portions and recipes differ by country.

WHAT THIS DATA CAN'T TELL US

One chain, one menu. 260 McDonald's items, US nutrition facts.

No sales volumes. A rarely ordered shake counts as much as fries.

Thresholds are ours. 50g sugar and 1,150mg sodium follow WHO and US daily values.



SOURCES AND TOOLS

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu, Kaggle (US menu, 260 items)

Sugar limit: WHO Guideline on sugars intake for adults and children (2015)

Sodium warning: NYC Department of Health, Sodium Warning Rule

Kids' meal drinks: California Department of Public Health, SB 1192 fact sheet

Tools: Looker Studio dashboard and D3.js. Built with AI assistance (Claude); analysis and recommendations by Group 3.

Data: Nutrition Facts for McDonald's Menu (Kaggle, US menu, 260 items). Sugar limit: WHO guideline, under 10% of energy, about 50g on 2,000 kcal.

NOTES

BEHIND THE STORY · **HOW IT WAS BUILT**

Data + visuals + a story

One dataset, one highlight colour per slide, one decision at the end. The arc follows Brent Dykes; the hero framework follows Session 7.

Slides **8**

RULES WE KEPT

- Highlight palette: grey everything, colour one thing
- Key on every slide, labels at the mark
- White space, no 3D, no truncated axes



Story arc: Brent Dykes, Effective Data Storytelling · Highlight palette: Session 3 · Hero framework: Session 7

CHARACTERS
Hero: the council
Guide: Group 3

SETTING
A fast-food ban on the table
260 items, one menu

CONFLICT
A blanket ban misses the real problem
Sugar is in the cup, salt is on the plate

RESOLUTION
Four targeted measures
Pilot first, then decide

READING LIST · BOOK OF THE DAY, SESSIONS 1–7

The Business Case for AI
Kavita Ganesan

Effective Data Storytelling
Brent Dykes

Learning to See Data
Ben Jones

Present Beyond Measure
Lea Pica

ColorWise
Kate Strachnyi

Storytelling with Data
Cole Nussbaumer Knaflic

Visualize This
Nathan Yau